Ankle Sprains in Female Athletes: Soccer vs Basketball

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WHY THIS MATTERS

Ankle sprains are one of the most common injuries we see in female athletes — especially in high school and collegiate settings.

But not all ankle sprains are the same.

Different sports create:

- different **mechanisms**
- different **severity levels**
- and different **return-to-play timelines**

That matters.

If we treat every ankle sprain the same, we're missing the actual problem.

WHAT THE DATA SHOWS

Looking at high school female athletes:

- Girls' basketball has the **highest overall ankle sprain rate**
- Girls' soccer is **right behind it**
- Over **50% of ankle sprains happen during games**, not practice
- The majority come from either:
    - player contact
    - or non-contact movement breakdowns

Two things stand out:

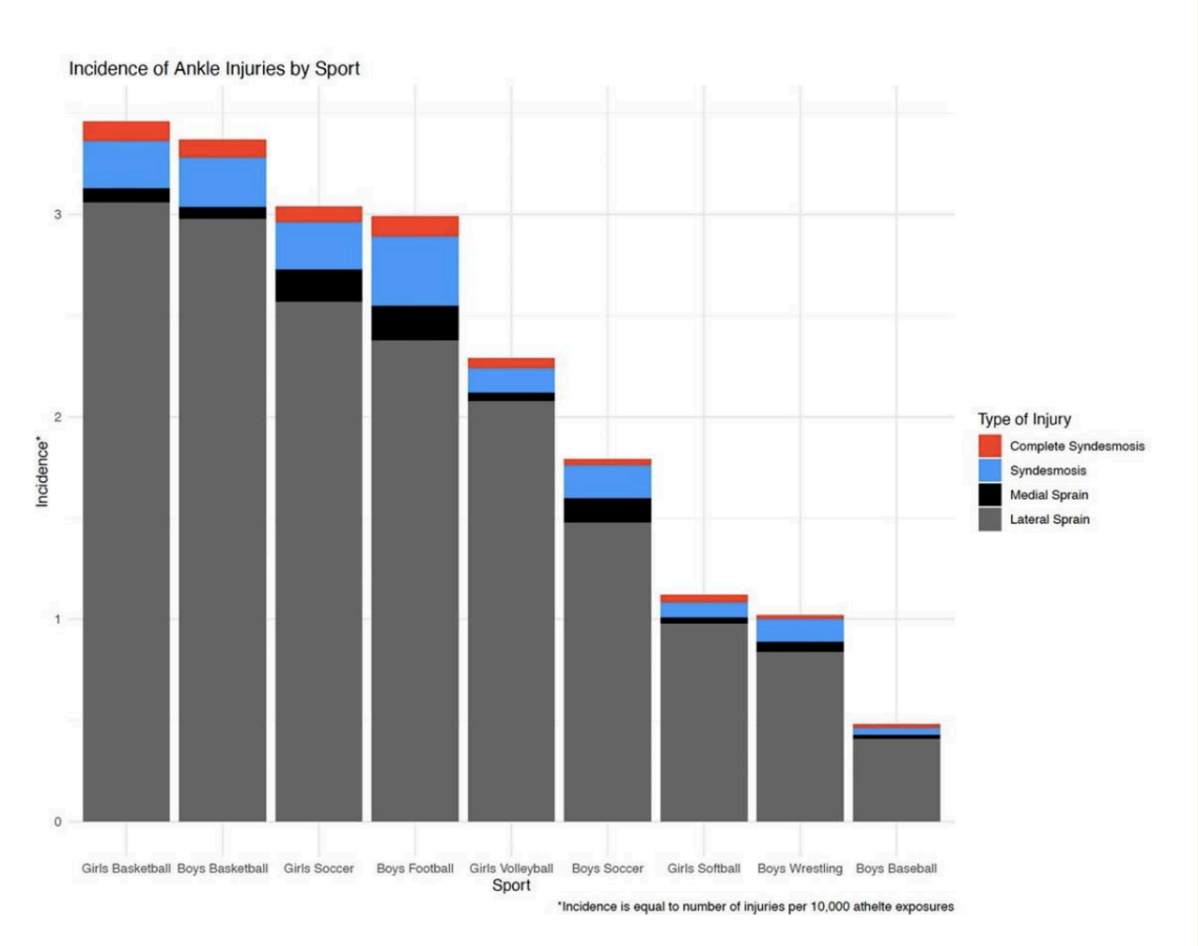
1. **~15% of ankle sprains are recurrent**

2. **Non-contact injuries are increasing over time**

That second point matters most.

This is not just bad luck.

This is a movement + load problem.



SOCCER VS BASKETBALL: WHAT'S ACTUALLY DIFFERENT

Basketball

- Higher overall injury rate
- More exposure to:
    - jumping
    - landing
    - contact (especially under the rim)

Most common scenario:

landing on another player's foot

Soccer

- Slightly lower overall rate
- But more:
    - time-loss injuries (>21 days)
    - non-contact mechanisms

Most common scenarios:

- cutting
- deceleration
- uncontrolled inversion

THE REAL DIFFERENCE

Basketball = frequency problem
Soccer = severity + movement problem

GAME VS PRACTICE RISK

This is one of the most important findings:

- Injury rates are significantly higher in games than practice
- In many cases, 2–3x higher

Why?

Games involve:

- higher speed
- more chaos
- more contact
- fatigue + decision-making

Practice doesn't replicate that.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR REHAB & PERFORMANCE

This is where most rehab programs fall short.

They're:

- too general
- too low-level
- not specific to the sport

For Basketball Athletes

You need:

- landing control under load
- frontal plane stability
- ability to tolerate contact

Not just:

- bands
- balance work
- “light movement”

For Soccer Athletes

You need:

- deceleration mechanics
- cutting at speed
- ankle stiffness + reactive strength

Not just:

- jogging → running → cleared

For Both

You have to address:

- non-contact risk factors
- re-injury risk (~15%)

That means:

- strength
- neuromuscular control
- progressive loading
- actual sport demands

BOTTOM LINE

Ankle sprains are not random.

They follow patterns.

- Basketball athletes get injured more often
- Soccer athletes often lose more time

- Most injuries happen in games
- Non-contact injuries are increasing

FINAL THOUGHTS

If you want to actually reduce ankle sprains:

You don’t just rehab the ankle.

You train:

- the athlete
- the movement
- and the demands of their sport

Reference

Kerr ZY, Nedimyer AK, Simon JE, et al. The Epidemiology of Ankle Sprains in US High School Sports, 2011–2012 to 2018–2019 Academic Years. Journal of Athletic Training. 2022;57(11/12):1030–1038. doi: 10.4085/1062-6050-0664.21.